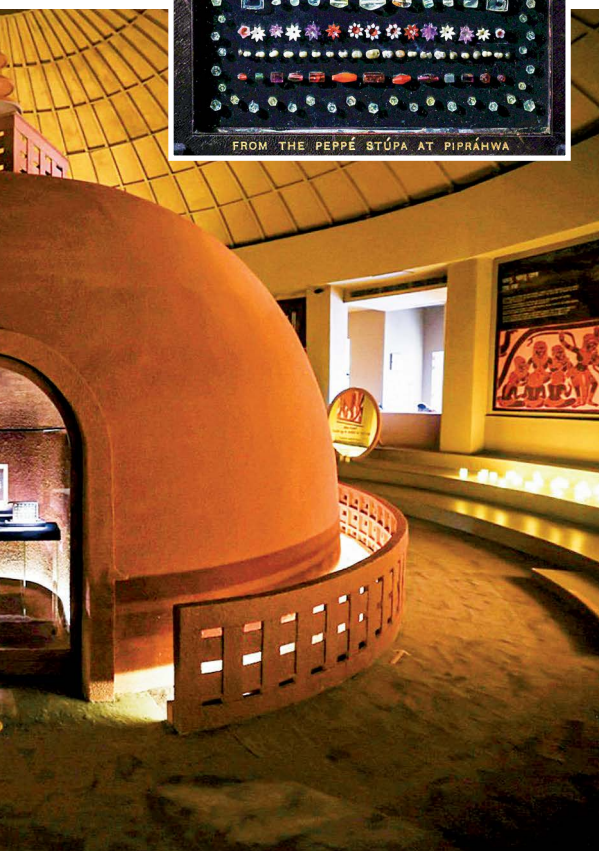
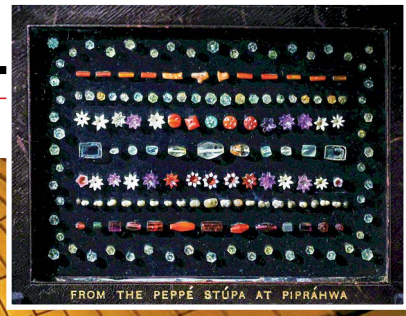



FROM THE PEPPÉ STÚPA AT PIPRÁHWA

of gold and carved gemstones. Most of this was kept in the Indian Museum, Kolkata, while Peppé kept about one-sixth of the treasure. It was this part of the Piprahwa relics—349 gems kept by the Peppé family—that was going to be auctioned at Sotheby's, Hong Kong, in 2025, when the Indian ministry of culture intervened. The Godrej group financed their return.

These repatriated gems are the *raison d'etre* of the exhibition, *The Light and the Lotus: Relics of the Awakened One*, forming a disproportionately tiny but central part of it within a recreated stupa structure. They are accompanied by the urns and other Piprahwa gems from the Indian Museum. One has to strain to see the tiny bone fragments of the Buddha (lent by the National Museum, Delhi), and the thrill is indescribable! At its heart, the exhibition, suffused by an air of reverence, celebrates the coming together of the original stupa's contents.

Large audio-visual presentations on Piprahwa lucidly explain how the stupa developed over three stages (Sakya, Ashokan, Kushana), the story of its excavation and after, and the inscriptions that prove that this was indeed the site of the Buddha's relics. A rich supporting display of historical Buddhist artefacts includes beautiful 2nd-century Gandhara sculptures; ancient reliefs depicting the Buddha's life and passing; 12th-century painted folios; modern thangkas and paintings; and Buddhist iconography from other countries. Appositely, in a 2nd-century Kushana relief, Drona is still dividing the corporeal relics of the Buddha among the kingdoms. ■

—Juhi Saklani

On view at Rai Pithora Cultural Complex, Delhi; 9 am-9 pm; Mondays closed. Entry free

The Indian Picturesque: Landscape Painting 1800-1850

Are landscapes the flavour of the season? This exhibition at DAG juxtaposes British and Indian landscape paintings from the early 19th century—including **George Chinnery**'s exquisite 'Oxen by a Thatched Dwelling, India'—and seeks out their 'artistic interconnections and shared visual vocabulary'.



▲ **TILL MAY 2** | ***DAG***, *Delhi*



◀ **TILL APR. 11** | ***Gallery Espace***, *Delhi*

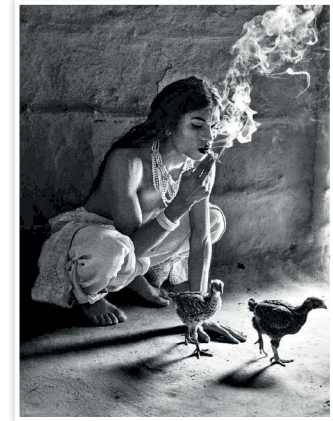
The Chair Project

Architect **Gautam Bhatia**'s recent sculptures of chairs are not merely quirky, they're downright provocative. The gallery calls them 'a satirical lens on the seats of power' and the sculpture titles hint at what to expect: 'Badly Packed Chair', 'Windblown Chair', 'Chair Within Chair', 'Growing Chair', 'Half Chair', 'Execution Chair' and so on.

▼ **TILL APR. 12** | ***NGMA***, *Bengaluru*

I TO EYE: SHADES OF HUMANITY

Asha Thadani is one of our most important contemporary photographers, noted for her empathetic depiction of India's marginalised communities. Through 16 photo stories, she explores the universal themes of justice, equality and social inclusion.



—compiled by Amit Dixit